When he refused, da Gama bombarded the city with his cannons for two days. To reinforce his message, several hundred captured Muslim seamen were hanged from the yardarms of da Gama's nineteen vessels – although not before their hands, ears and noses had been cut off. A boatload of these off-cuts were then sent to the Zamorin with the instruction that he should make a *karil* out of them.

That word *karil*, incidentally, marks the first appearance in Western lexicography of the Tamil *kari*, meaning a 'sauce', out of which the ubiquitous word 'curry' evolved – part of a scarcely perceived but dramatic cultural change for which we must thank, or curse, the Portuguese, for it was they who within a century and a half had transformed the South Indian diet into 'Madras Curry' and variations thereof by introducing from the New World potatoes, tomatoes, maize, peanuts, capsicum peppers and, above all, the fiery chilli, while at the same time challenging the Brahminical ban on onions, garlic and all root vegetables pulled from the earth!

Da Gama continued as he had begun, with further acts of what can only be described as terrorism, designed to send shock waves up and down the coast. Indian rulers and traders alike learned to deal with the Moors at their peril, and when shipping resumed along the coast it was by authority of the Portuguese and the Portuguese only.

The Portuguese acted in the conviction that theirs was the only true religion and that they had a duty to extend its blessings to all, convictions held with equal passion by the people they saw as their chief enemy, the Arabs or Moors. What made the difference in South India was that the Portuguese brought with them leadership and unity of purpose, encapsulated in their mission statement: 'Christians and spices'. Their actual numbers in India throughout the sixteenth century were tiny, but that unity, combined with European advances in ship-building, armaments and military training, was enough to destroy the Arab sea-trade and win them the secure enclave of Goa,